



Tech boobos

An autopilot that ran amok to a stowaway in space, a look at spectacular failures in technology. <https://digit.in/jun20-130>



A decade of failures

An exhausting list of all the products that failed to make it over the last decade. <https://digit.in/jun20-131>

flipped. Each card would contain text and graphics, much like a web page. It was a way to share information before the WWW – and the WWW is the way we eventually shared informa-

And gradually we've come back to Microsoft's original idea in the end. In fact, many would consider their latest Surface devices to be superior to the iPad in many ways, especially for professionals and creators.



The concept of displaying images with text and hyperlinking "cards" was inspired by this

tion, and built the internet itself. Who knows how many applications HyperCard inspired, because it was the first to "layout" words with pictures on the "internet". It was the first to make buttons for those "cards", etc. Even Sir Tim Berners-Lee has said he was inspired by the interlinking of "cards" in HyperCard, and developed the way pages link in the WWW.

MICROSOFT TABLET

Another Microsoft first that flopped. Microsoft was the first to release a tablet PC, and they did it with what was essentially a laptop with a touchscreen that used a pen as an input device. Being a software company and not wanting to step on the toes of its partners, Microsoft drew up some specifications for what a tablet PC could be in 2001. By 2003 OEMs had started making Tablet PCs according to the specs Microsoft recommended, in order to be able to run their Tablet PC operating system. This is probably why Microsoft's idea of a tablet PC failed, while Apple's iPad was such a runaway success. In fact, with the drop in iPad sales, once the novelty of multi-touch wore off, people started realising that many things they wanted to do on a tablet (drawing, being the most obvious example) needed pen access. Typing needed a hardware keyboard.

SINCLAIR C5

A mad electric bike, made by a mad Englishman inventor, the Sinclair C5 is was a single-person, battery-operated, pedal-assisted vehicle, that looks very cool to us at least. Named after its inventor, Sir Clive Sinclair, the C5 was a mad bike that the British people mostly ignored. For start-

ers, it was an electric bike, with no protection from the elements, being sold in a country that has unpredictable weather that is usually cold enough for people to not want to get wet. Add to that a range of a mere 32 km (peak), and you knew immediately this was more of a gimmick than a serious electric vehicle. Still, it was mad, and those who bought it loved it. Much like a Tesla is these days... The main difference between a Tesla is that although it does mad things, it also matches up or surpasses all other cars in terms of performance.



The Sinclair C5 was a mad electric bike

AMBILIGHT

In 2002 Philips launched TVs that had bias lighting in them, and Philips called it Ambilight. The problem was, these TVs were so much more expensive that it just didn't make financial sense to invest in them. However, you can think of this concept as the origins of the idea

of bias lighting being made available to the end user. Now, with the obsession with RGB for everything and everyone bothered about how to impress with light, it's no wonder that this is coming back into vogue among the niche group of PC modders – PC monitors kits are readily available, to add bias lighting to monitors of all sizes!

SEGA ACTIVATOR

Released in 1993, the Sega Activator is an octagon controller for the Sega Genesis that sits on the ground, and uses infrared sensors to essentially do what the Kinect would many years later. People liked to use it to play fighting games, but it was hard to master, and seemed more like a handicap than an advantage.

NOKIA NGAGE

The father of smartphone gaming, the N-Gage was released in november 2002, and was on every kid's Christ-



Gaming meets phone

mas / New Year gift almost immediately, because it had all the basic functionality of a phone, but more importantly was a gaming device. It tried to entice young gamers away from buying a dedicated hand-held console such as the Game Boy Advance, and also eat into the phone market as well. It sold 3 million devices, so it was not a flop by any stretch of the imagination, and this writer remembers spending hours with it after the review was done in 2003. But what it did show us was a future where one device would be able to do more than one thing, and boy did convergence become a reality!

Have we missed any of your favourites? Would your top 20 list be different? Write in and let us know. [d](#)